Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Billy Bauer

Guitarist Billy Bauer defines the word versatility. His career has included work with big bands, small swing combos and experimental jazz ensembles. He was born in New York on November 14, 1915 and learned the banjo at an early age. Billy was able to use his music to work during the depression years and became a full time musician by his early twenties. He played in Woody Herman's first Herd and with a long list of great jazz soloists, including Lee Konitz, Lennie Tristano, Benny Goodman and J.J. Johnson. Billy was a member of the Metronome All Stars from 1947-53 and was on staff with the NBC Orchestra. He has authored a book entitled Sideman*, and shares his experience in the world of jazz with students at his guitar studio on Long Island.*

Billy was interviewed in New York City on March 22, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in New York City. And I am really pleased to have Billy Bauer as my guest, who has been playing guitar for many years, and braved some inclement weather to be with us this morning. So I really appreciate it.

BB: This is a cool day.

MR: A cool guy and a cool day. I would like to ask you first about your guitar institute that you're working on, your guitar business, your school.

BB: Well it isn't a big school, but what I do, I mean if I had to earn a living I couldn't do it. But being the way I am, like at this part of my life, I like to see people and how they want to do things, these fellas take — some of them throw away everything. They think they're going to be big stars or something. And they make their own record dates and they put everything they've got into this. So I try to tell them, you know, go ahead. It's your turn to roll the dice. And then they say how did you — I says don't do what I did. You know you've got your own life and I generally, when they get doing it they want to copy, and I try to tell them listen to other people that came before, like Lester Young or somebody like that, and sing their part. Don't play it. Because on guitar, I don't know if you're familiar with guitar, but guitar, you get set fingerings and you're really not improvising, you're playing the same fingers. You know like for instance I say do you know all your scales? This is the first time they come. Either they say no or yes. But if they say yes, I say well all right, play it. So they play it. I say play it in the fifth position. They play in the fifth position but they just move up, instead of playing G they're up like the B flat key but it's the same fingering. So I try to explain to them that they're playing their finger patterns — not that you can get away, guitar is a very, the fingerboard is odd. Like to read.

MR: So when you said that they're just moving their fingers up a few positions and then playing that they don't know the notes that they're playing? Is that what you're saying?

BB: That's right. They've got a finger pattern. Oh I know it's a third — they can hear it — but they don't know. So I say now if you're going to come to me, do you want to learn how to read? And when they say yes, then I say well then you have to know where everything is. And some of them are piano players and saxophone, violin, they can read music. But they can't find it on the guitar. See so that's my little project, is to shows them different ways of learning the guitar, doing it in the head, that they can sing in their head. Anyway, what was that question?

MR: We're talking about — how many students does your business have right now?

BB: Oh it does vary, about I guess most of the time it's around eighteen, something like that. If I teach three hours or four hours a day, you see, I'm losing my voice now. I had to go the doctor last year because I used to lose my voice so much I couldn't talk because I sing with them. [scats] All that kind of singing. See so I'm doing that all day and he says there's nothing wrong, like you've not got anything wrong like cancer of the throat, but you've got weak whatever this is called, throat muscles.

MR: Larynx?

BB: Yeah. Like they're weak. So that's why everybody recommends — I say hello, they say oh Billy. And I don't know them that well. See so I've got a very distinct sound, not that it's good but it's different. Well anyway.

MR: Well you said an interesting thing before, they ask you well how did you do it, and you say well don't do what I did. But let's talk about what you did.

BB: All right. Well the reason I give them, they say well you know like you say listen to Lester or Charlie or one of them guys. They says but that would be imitating. I says you can never imitate the same. Because they says what do you mean, we could play it. I says you see that? What am I showing you?

MR: Your thumb.

BB: Yeah. And a fingerprint. Every one of us has got a different fingerprint see. So I tell them that. So don't be afraid, you ain't going to sound like them.

MR: Even if you try you're not going to.

BB: Even if you try. See and one time when I was, well you know I did a lot of different kinds of things. I was in big time but I wrote a book you know.

MR: I know you did.

BB: *Sideman*. Well that's what I probably was all my life. You know, even if I was the leader I was still, when I led the group it was like, you know, if Clark Terry was there, he'd be the leader for that night. Well anyway, what was I saying?

MR: Well I wanted to talk about, you said an interesting thing—

BB: I hope you have a lot of cuts.

MR: Oh we can cut and snip if we want. But you said an interesting thing about how some of the younger players come to you and they make their own record dates and the whole thing. Would it have occurred to you, when you were let's say 21, to go out and make your own record?

BB: No. I didn't think of that at all. But that's the way the world is today. But then again I'm saying in the beginning, a record date, was like I didn't even have a place and I had an old victrola. You know so records was like — I could go back so far, that radio wasn't even – that's a long time.

MR: Well I want to actually. Let's see it all started in 1915 in November, right?

BB: Yeah.

MR: You were born in New York?

BB: Yeah. I was born in the Bronx.

MR: And did you have a musical environment in your house?

BB: Well see when these questions are asked of me, I don't know. It seemed — now maybe it was just my household or my family or mother, but when we all got together for anything, like a dinner or a party, we all sang. You know that was the entertainment they sung [sings] "by the old mill stream." And you sing that.

[Billy & Monk sing together]

BB: You see? We all used to do that.

MR: You were harmonizing.

BB: Yeah, but I didn't know.

MR: It was part of your life at that time.

BB: Yeah. Well everybody, every corner had like a little quartet, I think they put a name like the Barber Shop Quartet, but everybody did that. And the only instrument we had at that time was one of these piano rolls, and they had the lyrics on them as they come down. So we all stand around the piano and sing. And my mother played a little piano. And my father, well I never seen him perform, I seen him do it in the house then. But he was called Harry, his stage name supposedly was Harry Nelson. He says he sings, and then he'd come out and he'd do the amateur hours and get the hook. If he got the hook he'd get four dollars. If he just stayed in he'd get two dollars. If you got the hook the hook means that you're so rotten and everybody said get him off, and that big hook would come out and grab you. So if they didn't have anybody, they'd pay you to be the hook.

MR: That's good. So was that considered vaudeville?

BB: Well you mean my father? Well that was Amateur Night that I'm talking about. But it was vaudeville. There was nothing else but vaudeville, and the movies was silent movies.

MR: How much did it cost to get into the movies when you were a kid?

BB: Oh gee, well now we used to call it a nickelette. So that was just the movies. But a vaudeville show was probably about 25 or 30 cents or something. I know it's hard to believe. Well whenever anybody says — you know these young fellas, they go out and they do these club dates, and I says well how— He says you'll never get, like you can't earn a living. I says well how much do you get when you do these? Well he says $150. And they've got two or three over the weekend. I says that's quite a lot. They says no, that ain't no good, you get with the big offices, you do good. You know he says they're gypping me. So I don't know what to say. So I tell them, I says lookit, when I was young, what was a postal stamp? Not so far back, like two cents, right? Then it went up to three cents, everybody went wild. Now, 32 cents. That's the difference with your money.

MR: That's right. What did your father do for a living?

BB: He was a printer. He was really a song and dance man like I said, and he made, there was an audition — I wasn't born about this time but he'd tell me that the audition was Ned Wayburn "School Days." It got to be a big Broadway show. And they went up to Ossining, New York to break it in. And he made it as one of the guys in the cast, not the star. And as he went up to Ossining, which isn't far from the Bronx, and his father told him if he could quit for show business was out. My grandfather, he thought that that was bad. So he says if you don't, you ain't got no place there, get out on your own. So my father got afraid, and come back and my grandfather was a printer, he became a printer. And he tried to do, later he tried to do the same thing with me. You know like because I started when I was nine. I broke my leg, my father bought me a ukulele while the girl pushed me around in a baby carriage, they didn't have no big things, they just got an old baby carriage. And I was laid up for a couple of months with this big cast, you know you had a cast on your leg. You mind me telling you all this?

MR: No I want to hear this.

BB: So to keep me busy, he gave me a ukulele. At that time Harold Teen and Cliff Edwards, Ukulele Ike. And they'd play "five foot two, eyes of blue, koochie, koochie—" and that kind of thing. And for some reason I learned a couple of chords, and by the time my leg was better at the end of the summer, me and my cousin went on to summer school, the two ukuleles, we'd practice all day, and we got out there. Well I have this in my book you know. And you mind me telling you?

MR: Please.

BB: They pushed us, it was our act. We got out there and we both froze. You know well we were never on the — I was never on the stage and the damn stage, the people were — so I ran up the stairs and I ran right into a little girl's dressing room. So they pushed me back on to the stage. By the time I got back my cousin was gone, he must have took off. So I don't know what I did. I know I went — so they gave us ice cream, that was the end. But

that was the first time I was ever in front of an audience you know. And from then, then he got me a mandolin for a little while. I didn't like it. It isn't that I didn't like it, I didn't know what to do with it. Then he got me a banjo. And I've still got the banjo.

MR: Still the same one?

BB: Yeah that he bought. It was about a hundred dollars, so it was a Weymann banjo, and it's a great banjo, but I've used it all these years.

MR: And a hundred dollars at that time was significant.

BB: It was a lot, yeah. And he thought because I could do these things.

MR: But did it ever get to the point where all of a sudden your father was saying now wait a minute, this music stuff is okay for fun—

BB: Oh yeah, yeah. Well then after he got me the banjo, then he got me a teacher in a candy store. The guy owned a candy store and I'd go back there and he'd show me. But he did do one thing. I had two banjo teachers. And they at least tried to make you learn how to read music. You know it wasn't like C or nothing like that, it was written out and you had to learn where everything is. Now they have all the, like Harry Reser's, he was a popular band leader, Cliquot Eskimos I think they were called. Harry Reser, he played like a violin player would play, you know, those banjo solos. So I had that environment, which I try to tell these kids that helped me out because at least I saw music in front of me. Where some of them now, they just see G seventh, and then — well now they're coming to me, they come to me and they say what's that called, what's that called. Oh what's a flat nine, what's a — I says wait a minute. Flat nine. I says you know the old Italian guy, he comes in, he's sitting on his porch, he's just got done playing with the grapes all day long, his hands are all cut and callused. And he sits on his porch, he has his bottle of wine there, and he drinks a couple of wines and he picks up his guitar and he goes [scats]. If you can't do that, forget it. You know what I mean? Like make it that everybody's dancing and singing music. You know what I mean? You know what the first question I ask them after they get all through telling me they played with this Rock group and that group. I says you want to learn how to read? They say yeah, that's why I came, I want you to, I heard that you make me read. I says well what's a note? You don't want me to ask you.

MR: What's a note?

BB: Yeah, what's a note?

MR: What's a note. Well it's a duration of sound.

BB: Well that's close. But they either say it's a pitch or something like that. What it is is a set of regular vibrations. A musical note. See if it isn't set, it isn't musical. And that goes, and it has four elements. So I says that's all I talk about. When you're talking and playing for me, I'm picking your weakest one and I'm showing you what your weaknesses are.

So I say what are they? They don't know. I say what's a musical tone? I don't want to embarrass you.

MR: What's a musical tone?

BB: Yeah. A note represents a musical tone.

MR: All right. Well a tone has pitch.

BB: That's one.

MR: It has length.

BB: That's called duration.

MR: Duration. Yes. It has volume.

BB: Dynamics.

MR: Dynamics, okay.

BB: Very good.

MR: And it has — oh boy — inflection?

BB: Well timbre. It's the sound, the sound.

MR: The particular sound of that.

BB: Yeah. It could be two instruments — well it could be the same instrument and you've got to get your sound to come out. That's why you know like if I take a guitar player, you know, and I've got a French guy, he come over from France. And he's a Django Reinhardt, he thinks he's a Django Reinhardt. I says well that's all right but you're a traditionalist. So don't forget, I told you you're a traditionalist. I says a lot of the guys playing Dixieland, you know, they play Dixieland music. I say I'm not a traditionalist. I don't care what you play. If you want to play you play. But a traditionalist would be somebody who's staying like Dixieland or Django Reinhardt, like 50 years ago. But I seem to go from — wherever I go I seem to get in with other guys and I guess I've got some kind of a thing that I blend with them in some sort. I don't hurt their playing. And that's a big deal, I try to tell them.

MR: That's an important phrase right there. Don't hurt their playing.

BB: Oh well sure. That's right. That's why you might not play so good, but they play good. And I think Louis Armstrong, when I listen to Louis Armstrong, some of his early bands, I'd say gee why is he having a saxophone player, that guy, he don't play that good you know. But now I realize that Louis could play good with these guys. You know, like if you get with some good players, sometimes they sound good but you feel them crowding you out.

MR: Yeah. This is my date.

BB: Yeah.

MR: Well anyway, you pursued the banjo for a while. How did you get into the guitar, and what time was that?

BB: Well now the banjo I kept going because I had my own radio show, like I didn't get paid for it, but it was WHN like in Loew's State building. I was there for six months all alone, no piano or anything. I just played these solos.

MR: Did you sing too?

BB: No.

MR: Just banjo solo. Wow.

BB: I wish I would have taped some of it you know. Well anyway, from there I got in with some bands, like one was in the Pelham East Theater. I think that's where, that's in the Bronx, and that was like they had a girlie show, and we had the violin player was the leader and he played C melody sax. And we had a tenor sax, two tenor saxes, a trumpet player, piano, drums. No bass. And me on banjo. But guitar was coming in. So I got a guitar but I couldn't hear the guitar. I mean because there was no mic. So I couldn't hear the guitar, so what I did I went out and I bought I think they call it a dobro. It's got a metal plate in it. It was a National guitar. Dobro?

MR: Oh, dobro.

BB: Yeah that's it. But I didn't know it. I thought it was — but I could hear it a little better because I had this resonator in it I guess you'd call it. So whenever I'd get like a tune that was in C or G, I'd pick the guitar up, and eventually, little by little, the banjo was out and the guitar was in. See I used the banjo because I used to go on in the floor show I'd play "Stars and Stripes Forever" or something like that. But then the banjo went out and I just got to know the guitar. I didn't take lessons right away on it, but I did have the advantage of reading music from the banjo, so I was trying to find that on the guitar you know, which some of these fellas don't have.

MR: Can you recall what kind of money you were making on those first engagements with this band?

BB: Well it's different areas. When I first went out I was, there was days when everything was illegal. There was no liquor, so it was prohibition. So everything I went with, even club dates, if they served liquor illegal so the girls, we used to have a kitty. And we'd have three pieces, like a drummer, banjo and saxophone, that was it. And the girls would pass the band and say, "Hey, play 'Melancholy Baby.'" And they'd give them a tip. So they'd throw — so one night I come home and I had twenty-five dollars on my dresser. Oh I didn't get paid twenty-five dollars, I got paid something like three or four dollars. But if it was a good night with these girls, and everybody was drinking, then all the girls got them drunk, the more they — So my father woke me up, he says, "Where'd you get that money?" Because he was only making about forty five dollars a week. So I tell him, I says we had a very good night. There was a couple of guys there and they just kept on giving us tips, so that was my end, we made seventy-five dollars in tips, which was a

good night. So anyway, but the average job was about four, five dollars, you know, that was a job. But when I had my own group, they picketed the place. The union was coming in then, Petrillo. So the boss didn't want the picket lines around the place. So he says join the union. So the guy comes in who was the head picketer, he says, "All right, so what do we have to do to join the union the boss asks." And so he says they each have to give twenty-five dollars. And you've got to come down and see if you read. But because you've got a job, you don't have to come down, give us the twenty-five dollars. Well they were trying to get in, and we were working. So on that job when it became legal, I was the leader, I made thirty-five dollars. Seven nights a week. And no hours. You got there at nine o'clock. But if there was people there at 3:30 —

MR: You just kept playing.

BB: Yeah. And seven nights too. And the guys would make twenty-five dollars see. And like I tell the guys, like that's where I got most of my training, because when you sit like six and seven hours a night, seven days a week and you just play, by the end of the night, you get so relaxed with playing. Because there was hardly any rest. Like you'd play, and then a girlie would go on and sing or dance or something, and then you'd play another for the dancing, and then another one. So you had the instrument. So I said you poor guys, you don't have that advantage. The only thing you can do is get around with each others in the house, or play with the records. I says but this was like a thing.

MR: That was like school for you.

BB: Oh, you can't buy that. Even sitting in, that's what they're trying to do, but it isn't as regular as that. You know like and generally it would wind up to be a lot of cutting, you know, this guy plays this. And this place I ran, I had noted, my theme song was "No Sitting In at the Sherwood Inn." Well I mean Friday and Saturday, and every night I had a different band. Like I had a different drummer, different bass player, and whatever the horn player was. And everybody came there, like Milt Hinton, Bobby Hackett, Clark Terry, all of them, Zoot, Al, they all came. Lee Konitz came.

MR: And this was where? At the Sherwood Inn?

BB: Yeah. That was in New Hyde Park, right near where I live. I had everybody there.

MR: Can I take you back just a few years — you were a teenager during the depression?

BB: Well I was just about — what year was the depression?

MR: The depression was mid-30s.

BB: '38 or something like that? I don't think I was a teenager. I remember my father, he went out selling apples for a nickel a piece. That's how he had to make enough. Because it got so bad.

MR: Did he lose his job during that time?

BB: No, no he didn't lose — I guess he did lose his job because that's all he was doing. See he wound up to be — the whole family was printers outside of me. So his father wanted him to be a printer, and he became a printer. But then his father was older with his father's brother, it was an uncle I guess of mine, but I didn't know him very much, but they were old-time. And my grandfather couldn't get along with his brother. And they had a fight. So that means my father and him were out. So my grandfather, he didn't have no business then. And he went to work for a newspaper, I think it was the *Bronx Home* or *North Side News*, which eventually became the *Bronx Home News*. And don't forget, my father went to the ninth — I went to the ninth grade elementary school, I quit. My father went to sixth grade and he quit. My grandfather went to the first grade. One year and he quit and he went to work. And you know what he wound up to be? A proofreader in a newspaper. Well you know why because you learn on the job. I tell these stories because that's why I try to tell them, that's what I did with music you know. See because he said you know like what makes Sammy run, I think there was a story like that, you know, like he just worked around the newspaper, picked up all the trash, and all of a sudden, well that's what my grandfather did, but he did learn how to print because you see them setting type and then you learn, you didn't even know you were learning how to read and write. Well that's the best way to learn.

MR: That's a great story. I had something about you playing with a fellow named Jerry Wald?

BB: Jerry Wald. He thought he was — after a while, when I first got with him he was imitating Hal Kemp, the clarinet would be in megaphones with their hands through and it's a lot to get out of that kind of music [scats], but then Artie Shaw retired and Jerry got the big idea, so nearly overnight he got all of his arrangements, and the whole band changed. Then it was supposed to be like Artie Shaw you know. Yeah I worked with him in the Spanish Gardens in New York, did a broadcast, you know we were on, I guess every night they did the Band of America or something, they'd jump like a half hour in this place and then they'd be out in California. All the big bands would get a shot out there every night. I did it with Abe Lyman too.

MR: What age were you when you moved away, moved out of your family house?

BB: At 14 years old I had my own radio show. I was working in these speakeasies and things like that. Then a big out of town job came along, which was out in Far Rockaway. But you know I had to live out. Is that what you mean?

MR: Yes.

BB: When I moved out of the house. Yeah, so I went down to Rockaway and I stayed down there for almost a year. And from then on, when I did go home, I was always working. I'd just come in, say hello. And I was on the road with different bands. It was very early like, I didn't even know that I was young. The guys who were working, they'd call me

the big shot, to kid, they'd kid, he's a big shot. And I didn't know what the hell they were talking about. Evidently they thought I was someone.

MR: Right. Can I assume that your father eventually came to terms with your life as a musician?

BB: Well he wanted me to get a real job. That's what he classed it as. So I said gee, I like what I'm doing. He said yeah but you've got to get a real job, you're getting too old. I was about 18 or 17. He says you've got to get a job. He says come on down to the shop with me. So he brought me all the way down to 11th Street, down in New York where we are, and it was in the summer, and that means I had to take a trolley car to the subway, the subway and then I had to walk a couple of blocks you see, on a hot summer's day. No air conditioner. He opened the door to get into this big shop, it was Vannery's Press, it was, by the way he started off just picking up bags and everything. He wound up to be the foreman of this big print shop. You know they made big books like Bibles and things like that, it was Vannery's Press. He opened this door and the ink, the smell of ink hit me and I almost passed out. I said Pop, I can't make it. I couldn't see myself going there. So then he kept after me. You know he says geez, you've got to get something. So one of my friends who was a leader of one of the club date bands, he worked in Celanese, it's an imitation silk, but it was just starting, so he says they're hiring guys. I know how old I was, I was 16 at that time. Because NRA came in, and you got, it was $16 you were allowed to make, or you had to make $16 a week. So I went in to this Celanese, and after about six months the boss called me in and he says, "Hey, I hear you're a musician." I said, "Yeah, I play banjo and guitar." He says, "I'm a banjo player." He says, "Do me a favor. You take your lunch hour and then you come back and you come in my office." So I got talking to him there, and he says, "What the hell are you doing here anyway?" I says, "Because my father wants to see why I don't work, so I'm going to hold a job for six months or a year to show him I can do it." So he says, "Yeah but this job ain't nothing." He says, "You see them guys pushing them things around" the rolls of silk and whatever. He says, "They've been here for ten years." He says, "Every year I give them a buck or two bucks raise." He says, "They're married." He says, "You, so far in six months," he says, "I had you in the receiving clerk, you know, you're feeding the machines, double and fold machine," he says, "I give you everything, opening the crates," he says, "and you could do it." He says, "They can't do anything." I've got to keep them on the same job" he says. So then he offered me a job in the underwear department because the underwear department was new at Celanese. Am I boring you?

MR: No.

BB: The underwear department was just starting. So the old guy who was the head of it, he got sick. So he says, "You go down there," and he says, "we're going crazy. Every time

this guy don't come in, nobody can get any orders because he's got like a 42 blue over there, then he's got a 42 blue up there, and he's got it so mixed up that nobody can, it's all mixed up." He says, "Will you go down there and condense the stock?" I said, "I don't know what you mean, condense." He says, "Well you know, put all the blues together and the sizes together." I said okay. So I went down there and it was only a little room, it was just like here but bigger than that. So I put everything in order and I was sitting there. He come by and he says, "What's the matter, where are you, why aren't you working?" I said, "Well what do you want me to do?" He says, "I told you, condense." I says, "I did." So he comes in, and he looked at it and he says, "Hey, you want this job?" He says, "This job pays $35." And that was a lot of money, because he was only making about $60 at that time. He says, "And it's going to be big, you'll have guys under you."

MR: And you were 16?

BB: Yeah, 16, 17.

MR: Wow.

BB: I says, "I don't want this job," I says, "as a matter of fact I've got to quit" I says, "because I'm working every night in the Palanase Inn besides this." I was trying to show my father that I — so he says, "you're working every night," well he says, "don't quit now." He says, "Wait for two more weeks because the Christmas bonus is coming in and they're going to give each guy two weeks salary as a bonus because the company's doing so good." So I said, "Yeah but I'm getting so tired." He says, "I'll tell you what you do. You come in, you check in, and you go in the back bin and go up there and sleep." And he says, "If I need you, I'll call you." And that's what he did for the two weeks.

MR: This guy was pretty cool.

BB: Yeah. His name was Keyes, Mr. Keyes.

MR: That was pretty nice of him.

BB: Yeah, well he was a brainy guy.

MR: Well let me move up a few years.

BB: You'll never get through it.

MR: I know, I'll never get through it.

BB: I went on one of these interviews by radio, and oddly enough it was a snow storm, just like today. But I'm there and there's Phil Schaap.

MR: Phil Schaap, huh?

BB: Yeah, he's interviewing. And it was supposed to be for an hour. And we're talking and talking, and all of a sudden it's three hours. And my wife is out there. She come back, she says, "It's snowing." So I says to Phil, "I'd better go." He says, "Yeah, well right after this." And then we go on. So it got so bad, he says, "You've only got a little while longer,

you know" and then we go on for another three hours. So in the middle of the program, well it wasn't the middle, I says, "Phil, it's snowing outside. See you."

MR: We're done.

BB: And I went out on the radio in the car and I put the program on, and I was still on, only my records. He was playing "The Way You Look," he had all the outtakes. No but my mouth, I can't stop talking.

MR: I love it. Tell me about how Woody Herman came about.

BB: Well Woody was, I think that's in my book, I mean really how I got in with Woody you mean? Well I think Flip must have recommended me. Because he's the only one that I knew when I joined them. But Woody rang up. And he says, "This is Woody." I says, "Woody who?" I loved it. You know I wasn't, I don't know. So he says, "We're over in The Meadowbrook," and he says, "we're leaving tomorrow." He says, "Why don't you come over and sit in with us one set?" So I says, "Gee I can't do that tonight, Woody." He says, "Why?" I says, "Because it's my kid's birthday and I promised her I was going to be there." He says it's your kids, he repeated what I said. He says, "Okay I'll tell you what you do. You go down to the Goldfarb," and he gave me Radio City, blah, blah, blah, and he says, "And you go down there tomorrow and sign the contract and meet us in—" Now Flip says it was Cincinnati. I thought it was Detroit. And I forget what the name of the place was. But Flip says — well either case, that's what I did, I went down there and then I took a plane, they gave me money for a plane, I flew in and sat down to play. The interesting — well but the only one I knew, Davy Tough, joined the band with me at the same time, and Flip, and I don't know who else, but I got to know them. Oh I knew Flip, cause me and Flip used to do a lot of things together, little things.

MR: I think Flip said he played with the Cliquot Eskimo — what is that?

BB: The Cliquot Club Eskimos. Yes, you know it's a ginger ale, Cliquot Club. That was the advertiser. Harry Reser. Are you sure he said that?

MR: I think he did. Or maybe it was Jerry Jerome actually, I can't really remember.

BB: Flip played with Morgan. There was a Morgan he played with, and he played with Frankie Newton. That was his big thing. He was in in at Kelly's Stable, but he played clarinet at that time.

MR: So Woody Herman was the first big band that you had played with, of that size?

BB: Well no, I was with Jerry Wald, I was with, Abe Lyman, I was with Carl Hoff from the west coast, he hired me. And at that time I had to go and brush up on my reading because in Carl Hoff's band, the violin player was the arranger. There was only one violin, but he wrote double stops for the guitar and double stops for the violin so it would sort of sound like — that's the book when I come in — and they couldn't get any guitar player to read it. So I come closer to it, but I went down to Eddie Bell and told him gee, I'd better pick

up on my reading. So Eddie Bell says go and see Alan Reuss. But Alan was sick and he was going to go out to California. So I just went over two times with Alan. He says aah, keep doing what you're doing, it's all right. No, but that was lucky that I was taught how to read a little bit, on the banjo. See that's what I try to tell these guys. This month, I think it's May, April, May, I think it's May, *Jazz Guitar*, there's a magazine called just *Jazz Guitar*, they just sent me a proof of one of my solos I had recorded a long time ago. And I thought that was pretty crazy, if they're copying it off the record. But now I realize they copied if off my music. But what they wanted to do, they put it in tablature. And that's what I'm always against. I'm not against it, but if the guitar player reads that, he don't read the music you know. It's just like a block, like a cement block, that's what you get, one of these, that kind of thing. What do you play?

MR: I'm a saxophone player.

BB: I got a saxophone player now. What's odd about him — well not only him, I've got a cellist, I've got a girl who plays all the woodwinds, but she wants to get in jazz. She calls it jazz but what she really wants to do, she wants to go, and I've got a cellist — because he does these weddings in the churches or in the synagogue or wherever. I don't know. But he wants to get in, that he could do the dance part, and he realizes that he's got the wrong kind of, you know. And so they come to me to get a little looser or whatever.

MR: Well Woody Herman was 1944. Did you have to join the service?

BB: Yeah that was before I was with Abe Lyman, And in Abe Lyman's band we got in the USO. And at that time, I don't know if the war was coming down, but Glenn Miller, his band got shot up or something, and we were all — I was a Captain. I mean you know, like a captain rating it was. And I had all my shots, and everyday we'd play different embarkation camps around, all over Jersey, they'd fly us up to New England, and we'd play a show, but we never knew if we were going with them or not. They wouldn't tell you. You just said goodbye and you didn't know. And then the bus would bring you back. And the next day they'd say we're going to meet here. And that's because you couldn't talk you know.

MR: They never told you where you were going?

BB: No. They never told you. You were ready to go overseas. You were all ready to go. Because —

MR: What was the phrase: loose lips sink ships? Something like that. So they didn't want you to talk about where you were going.

BB: Yeah, that's right, that's right. So I said goodbye so many times. Then they screened all the people in my neighborhood. I didn't know this at the time then but the people started to tell my wife, they said, because they were going to send me to South America. They found out jazz was like the German Navy and the Italian Navy and the French Navy.

They were down around South America. That was — what do you call it — a country not at war.

MR: A neutral country.

BB: Yeah, a neutral country. So they found out they were going in to hear jazz. So they shipped some jazz bands in these little night clubs. So I was pegged to go down in there, in case it was — for a year, they called it you were the year. They sent me down and told me the job paid a hundred dollars a week. If you get killed, nobody knows anything about you. Your family gets nothing. They're telling me, this is it. The Army — you're not in the Army, you're a spy. All you had to do was play, and if you were sitting like with the Germans or the Italians or something, and they said well we won't see you for a while you know. And then every week or so you'd go to the embassy and say well this guy says he won't be around for a while, while they were putting it together, that they were shipping out, all that kind of thing.

MR: They wanted you to just give them information about—

BB: But nobody knew anything about this. They didn't want it. Because it was what kind of a country?

MR: Neutral.

BB: A neutral country. They didn't want to say that they were behind it you know. And then in the USO, it was a hundred dollars a week too, but nothing else. And if anybody, if you were in battle, you weren't shooting, but if you were in battle, your job, besides playing, was to pick up all the wounded or the dead. That was it. I mean you had to do that. I'm glad they didn't shoot me.

MR: Chubby Jackson, Bill Harris, Flip Phillips, there was quite a crew in that band.

BB: Well everybody at that time thought it was one of the swingingest bands. Especially for Offays. Do you know what Offays were?

MR: Yes I do. Those white guys can really swing, huh?

BB: Oh I had a lot of black players, they used to come in, like they would take me down the hall and then where Minton's was, and then there was another place down there. All the guys used to sit in, like the Basie band, not the band, but guys in the band you know, and they'd bring me down the hall and they liked me, I don't know. They'd just take me around, they'd protect me.

MR: You helped them sound good.

BB: I don't know. But they were very nice to me, and they'd show me, they'd tell me, so that's why I know about offays, because in one of these places, this was about four in the morning. I'd get through at three, and they'd meet me somewhere down around 125th Street, and we'd go around for a couple of hours. But at the bar, sometimes I was the only white guy there. And these guys would — this one guy's name was Slingshot. I said,

"Slingshot, this guy's banging me in the back all the time." He says, "Let's change places." So he got over there, and nobody — so he says, "Listen to them," and they would torture me, and say, "Hey go on there, rubber band." He says they're not talking about nothing, they're hijiving. Don't you want to hijive with them? You know, just talking. The rubber means automobile. And they had names for each thing. So he was explaining what they were doing. He said, "They ain't talking about nothing.

MR: And he said they were hijiving.

BB: Yeah. Hi jiving. And he says, like they say, that offay, he says, that means you.

MR: What kind of fellas, for the Basie band — was it Lester Young or let's see Buddy Tate, those fellas?

BB: You mean playing in these places?

MR: Yeah.

BB: I never seen the guitar player, Green, Freddie Green. But I became — in the place I didn't see him, maybe he was playing there but I didn't notice it. But later on we had Manny's, it's a music — it's still there I think Manny. He's dead but his son runs it. And they used to have a golf game every year and they'd invite all the big musicians who either deal with the store or hang out there, I don't know. Well I was invited a couple of times. And the one time I was playing and Freddie Green was there too. He didn't play, but we were in the golf game, in the tournament. And after, Manny would have all the instruments, not your instruments, he'd just have them there if you felt like picking it up. So I was playing, and that's how Freddie Green started to talk to me, he told me he says if my son wants to take a lesson I'm going to send him to you. He liked me. And well the other part of that, I'm not a great golfer. At that time I just played for fun. And Clark Terry was on my foursome. And I knew Clark. So Clark says, "Let's me and you have a bet" he says, "I'll bet you I'll beat you." So I says, "Well I don't play." He says "I don't play." We ruined the foursome, the other two guys were mad. We were behind trees. So at the end, Manny's got a motion picture you know, like a 16 millimeter or something, of the end of the game. It was in the Engineer's Club in Glen Cove, well it's right in Long Island.

MR: Glen Cove?

BB: Well I don't know if it's Glen Cove or what, but it was the Engineer's Country Club. Manny would hire it out for one day a week, nobody else but musicians, from morning to night we'd go there, they'd put us in the dressing room, they'd take our shoes and shine our shoes, when we come back out. It was ridiculous. And I'd have breakfast. So we'd go out and at the ninth hole he'd have hamburgers or hot dogs. At four or five o'clock when you finished the eighteen, they had a cocktail party. After the cocktail party we'd go in and get all dressed up, and go back into the dining room and that's where all the

instruments were set up, and we'd eat in there, the whole day. So at the end of this thing, he's got — I beat him, I don't know, I beat him by one stroke. It was terrible.

MR: You had 120 and he had 119?

BB: And he's flipping a quarter to me, and I'd catch the thing. So I bet Clark Terry.

MR: A nice moment.

BB: Oh he's a beautiful guy. And then at Flip's birthday party not so long ago, his 80th birthday, and oddly enough me and my wife got into this limousine, to pick us up at the airport, and he come in. So I told him I says the only thing I can beat you at is at golf. I ought to call him up right before we die and tell him to come on out and play golf. He probably took lessons.

MR: A re-match.

BB: Yeah he'd beat me.

MR: What was it like touring with Woody Herman? Was it mostly train or did you get cars that you traveled around the country in?

BB: No we had bus and train. Later on when we did some Army bases again, one time they put us in a plane. These Army bases they would like — giving them a free concert or whatever. They put us in a plane. The plane was stripped — nothing in it. A big like it was a—

MR: A cargo plane or something.

BB: Yeah, but nothing in it. No windows in it. And they put the parachute on us and strapped us in. That was our seat. We just sat on the floor. And you could fall out. Well that was Woody. And another time out in California they took us into San Diego and we had to play the show for the servicemen. But we couldn't live in San Diego. Because if you were a civilian you'd get beat up. So they shipped us 20 miles out on one of these coastal motels. They put the band there and picked us up and bring us to the back door to the concert stage, and they'd line up all soldiers on each side of us to protect us. They were afraid if we lived in San Diego we'd go out at night and being that we didn't have any uniforms on, we'd get beat up.

MR: Beat up by the servicemen?

BB: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: Okay, they didn't appreciate civilians. Yeah San Diego, there is a big military base there, right?

BB: Yeah, yeah. Well that was an awful— but we played all of them, you know, for the soldiers. It was good. That was with Woody. And I did it with Abe, too Abe Lyman.

MR: Tell me about the rhythm section with Chubby and you and Davy Tough.

BB: Yeah, and then we had a few piano players, but Ralph was the one that when I came there he was the piano player. That was a crazy business. It was, I guess a lot of it, just like that

shouting and everything, that was all Chubby Jackson. You know, "go ahead" and all that. And but the rhythm section with Davy Tough, I mean he just knew where, he wasn't a flashy drummer. As a matter of fact I met Flip, well I guess at his birthday, but he told me that the only solo that Davy every took is on my tune, which was I think "Skyscraper" that I recorded with Flip Phillips. A big hit.

MR: Let me play something for you.

[audio interlude]

BB: I mentioned it. Does Davy Tough take a solo here? It's a four bar solo.

MR: I love that chord in there by the way, that one little —

BB: [scats]

MR: It's pretty modern for the time.

BB: How'd you get that? Oh you knew I was coming so you—

MR: I knew you were coming. Actually it comes off this particular recording.

BB: Did you interview him?

MR: Yes we did.

BB: Yeah, I remember this record. Well I don't know if I'm on all of them.

MR: You're on this recording, yes.

BB: The whole record?

MR: A lot of it.

BB: Oh yeah? I was sick. One guy, on one of these tunes, he and I stayed on the same two notes through the whole release or something. So he says lookit what he did, he played a flat nine—

MR: Oh yeah, I see what you're saying.

BB: All he did was analyze it.

MR: He says oh yes, this is a very complex thinking process right? And you were just like —

BB: I didn't know what else to do.

MR: I love that stuff.

BB: You know it's sort of frumpy, but at that time, it's swinging.

MR: It's swinging.

BB: Yeah.

MR: And Chubby's on this too.

BB: Chubby isn't on this one.

MR: He's on some of the tunes. This is like a kind of a collection of Flip's, but they're mostly from forty—

BB: Did he say I wrote that tune?

MR: Yup, sure does.

BB: Because he called me up after he read the book and he says, "You didn't put my name on it." I says, "Look at the other page."

MR: Oh, check it out.

[audio interlude]

MR: That's wild. Did you write all that out?

BB: I guess I did. I don't know. I don't know about a drum solo.

MR: I don't know what happened to the drum solo.

BB: I don't know either. Well he says it's the one tune, that's the only four bar drum solo that Davy ever took.

MR: Was there other recordings of that tune, probably.

BB: I don't know.

MR: Well we'll have to research that.

BB: I'm surprised that Flip — well we wrote a couple of, we had a little sextet or whatever. It was good times. We used to just meet and I know we had a room at the hotel, I forget where the hell it was, I think it was with Abe Lyman. I think I got in, oh I know I got him on Abe Lyman's band, there was another guy, Russ Morgan? Was there a band by the name of Russ Morgan?

MR: It doesn't ring a bell with me.

BB: But anyway, when Abe, on account of the Army, Abe didn't want to take me out on the road for a ten week, you know the bands used to stay in a hotel, that was the business. Now I realize, I didn't know it then, but they'd stay in a hotel like the Lincoln, which isn't there anymore, and you'd do about ten weeks or three months in a hotel, and every night, or two nights a week you'd be on this radio you know. And then you'd go out and do one-nighters and colleges and things like that. So when you'd come back he says, "Lookit, Bill" he says, "for the eight weeks or so" he says, "I'm afraid to take you because I don't want to be stuck in the middle of this eight weeks or something." He says, "But when you come back will you open up in the St. Regis?" So he says, "I'll give you a call." So I says okay. So I went and did my business, whatever I was doing. He gave me a call and he says, "I need a saxophone player, a tenor." I says, "Why don't you get Flip?" But Flip, he couldn't read very good at the time. Well I told Abe, I says, "He isn't a good, good reader, but he's got good ears." But I don't even know why I said that. I'd never seen Flip really read. We used to do things just by ear you know what I mean? So he come there, and Abe liked him so he was in the UN with me too with Abe.

MR: We were talking before the cameras were rolling about one thing with Chubby Jackson. Something about he actually took you down one day, and who was the other fellow you were talking about?

BB: Oh Sonny Berman.

MR: Sonny Berman.

BB: Yeah. Well we used to kid around. We had a lot of different things. And Chubby was always, well I guess he was an athlete. You know he was a dancer, I know he always used to — I don't know if he could really dance — but he was always strong like, and he was big. At that time he was big. Is he big now?

MR: He's not big now.

BB: Well he was, see? And we was kidding around or something and Chubby says, "Ahh shut up, I'll give it to ya." So I don't know, Sonny says, "Yeah whadda ya mean?" And boom, he knocked him down. He didn't hit him, but he knocked him down and he pinned him down. And then he grabbed me—

MR: He put you down too, huh? He is a spark plug, I'll give him that.

BB: Oh yeah. And he played that way too. Like he wasn't sophisticated with what pitches you're playing or things like that.

MR: But he had the drive.

BB: That's right. And that's what does it after a while. Well Davy was, he was like, it's hard to say because he wasn't a drummer that was a flashy drummer, you know or something. But he'd get into a certain place and he would just stay there, you couldn't get him away from that, and the band would eventually get with him. With Max, I say that in the book too, like Max, when I played with him, I used to sit behind, down on 52nd Street, Charlie's band was out there and then I was in the back with the other band that, we'd split it, so when I was in the back, all the kids when I was teaching in this conservatory, it's called a conservatory, and they would say, "You've got to be cool, Daddy." I says cool? Who's cool? They says, "Yeah like Max Roach is cool." I say, "Max Roach is cool?" I says I'm sitting behind him on the bandstand and boom a broken stick comes back." I says, "He only feels like he's cool, but he's putting energy in there, you don't just fall apart. It's the feeling. So that's what Max was doing. [scats] and he'd push it up, and when he'd get it right where he wanted it, then he'd stay there and he'd play. You know and he did that even when I was playing with groups like that All Star date, and then we did that big broadcast — well, a big broadcast — but it was one of them battle of the bands, you know. I didn't think it was so good but evidently it's still put out on the market. But Max was the same way there. He'd get it up to where he wanted it. Like in the beginning you think you can't grab it, but then all of a sudden it levels off.

MR: It felt like he was speeding up kind of, or just the intensity?

BB: But I hate to say speeding up because he wasn't speeding, it was just like a little anxiety you know, like it wasn't where he wanted it. So and that's what makes a good player or a good band. And the good player, when he's in charge of us, if he's got the right guys you know and they're not mean or crazy or anything, but he just puts it in where he wants it to

be. That's part of the make-up, no matter what he plays it's in that groove. And that's the hardest — well it isn't the hard part, it's easy, but if you're looking for it you ain't going to find it.

MR: You played for a while in a smaller group with Chubby and Lennie Tristano?

BB: Yeah. That didn't last long.

MR: It didn't last too long.

BB: No, well see Chubby is a different type of player. He did that kind of playing. Lennie was, I don't know if you want to say sophisticated or what. But we played a couple of jobs together but really Arnold Fishkin, Chubby was supposed to come in — I thought Chubby would be with Lennie and myself and Chubby. Because Chubby operated this see. But he put Arnold Friskin with us, the bass player. But a couple of dates Chubby was angling around. One of them was on 52nd Street. And I was playing like I was playing with Lennie because Lennie didn't want me to play rhythm. He wanted me to do anything but don't play rhythm. You get with Chubby and Chubby going "come on!" Because he was looking to get somewhere, and Lennie would be laying back. Oh that was a miserable couple of nights. See they just—

MR: They just made a clash.

BB: Yeah, they are two different schools. Well Lennie always used to have trouble most of the time with drummers, because they would fill in. They were used to sort of bebop you know. And he didn't want them because they destroyed, well now I realize he could be playing other three beat or five beat phrases, and they'd put it in where they thought it should be and so he'd generally tell them just play time. See and Chubby was like that too with the bass. Well they didn't — not that they hated each other or anything, it was just the two people, their playing.

MR: I think I read something about you giving Lennie Tristano a driving lesson?

BB: Well I did do that.

MR: Is that one of those — did you really? And there was no accident at the end of it?

BB: No. I think I told Bill Crow, I guess it was Bill Crow—

MR: Yeah, I think it was.

BB: I says he wasn't a very good pupil.

MR: That's good.

BB: Well because Lennie, you know like we were pretty friendly, not in music as much as just two people. And I guess he had, I don't know maybe it was that way, but he'd talk about average things you know. Like what would we really like to do you know. I mean if you really, what would you — he says, "I'd like to drive the car." That's how that come up. Well I felt, well some day, at three o'clock in the morning, I'm alone on the road, I'll let you drive. And I did. Well like all of those things. But I used to talk to him. We'd have a

thing, he'd shut all the lights out in the room to see if I could compete with him on his deal. And then he'd beat me in these games in the bars, with the little puck, the bowling you know? He bowled a strike, I says, "How'd you do that?" I knew how he did it because he goes down and he measure the length of the board, and the width of it, and you know he feels it, and then he throws it.

MR: Well you've had I think a quite remarkable career in that you've moved from one kind of music to another with great skill, and I guess you said it earlier in the interview that you helped people, you didn't get in their way, you made them sound better.

BB: I don't know if I helped them, I didn't get in their way, that was the big thing. You know like I guess they could play, but I didn't think of it like that until now, when you get a little older you hear things, like you just was playing and I wasn't up to them guys. Well to me, I didn't have the knowledge — not Flip so much but Flip's got knowledge about playing — but I mean some of the other guys like Ralph Burns for instance, I worked with Nelson Riddle, I didn't realize that he was – Neal Hefti was another, Shorty Rodgers, like Shorty Rodgers on "Pam," him and Ralph Burns put the ending on it.

MR: On which?

BB: On "Pam." Woody had the recording. And they fixed the ending so it would sound like a little ensemble, which they never told me, they just did it. So they liked me.

MR: Well some other people liked you too.

BB: Not as a player, as a guy.

MR: But you, from '47 to '43 you played with the Metronome All Stars, is that right?

BB: '47 to '43?

MR: '47 to '53. I'm sorry. It's still early in the morning you know.

BB: And it's snowing out.

MR: Yes. I've been watching the time.

BB: I've got to go to a wedding. I'll put my tie on. I'm sorry I don't put a tie on.

MR: No, you're fine, believe me. In the Metronome All Stars with Diz and Miles and Charlie Parker.

BB: Well Charlie was sort of nice to me. Miles was funny with me. Dizzy was all right. I mean he talked to me. And Charlie was very good too. I mean if we were walking, I'd be in another place, across the street on 52nd Street, and he used to walk around with this horn and just sit in every night. He'd walk around with her in the summertime. He'd walk in and play a couple of choruses and walk out and go to the next. place Well heard me playing all the time you know, so I was very surprised, I don't know, like I said this before, but when me and Serge was coming home from one of them All Star dates, and we were in the car, and talking, just talking like this. And Serge said something like, "Do you realize we were on the All Star tape, like the biggest thing in the country, like Dizzy

and Charlie" blah blah blah. So I says, "Yeah well that's because you know like we just happened to do." He says, "Well what would make you happier than that?" I says, "If Charlie called me up for his record date." And within a couple of weeks I'm sitting there, "Oh, BB?" I says, "Yeah?" "This is the Bird." See so.

MR: There you go.

BB: That's right. I didn't do so good but he did it.

MR: That's neat.

BB: Well I mean it's satisfying. So no matter what anybody says to me you know, you're not so good, blah, blah, blah. I said well you do it then. You know like a lot of my, especially guitar players, and they can play better than me really, you know like we sit down — so they said how did you get so big? I says I don't know. I said the phone rang.

MR: And you did it, yeah.

BB: Yeah, so they keep on saying. I says well why don't you do it? I can't help it. You know what I mean? And they are good, but maybe it's this other quality, that I can get along with these people. Just like we're sitting here talking, you don't feel any strain to make me talk, do you?

MR: No certainly not.

BB: Can I have all the outtakes? How long is that?

MR: We can wrap up pretty soon here, because I know you have to get going. Here's a hard question maybe. How's that for an introduction?

BB: Yeah wait a minute, that's what Phil Schaap says. I was talking to him and we got going, and he says, "I'm going to look that up," he says, "you've got me worried." He says, "I used to think I knew everything, but when you questioned it—" and that same program after I got back, Jimmy Hall rang me up, and he says, "Me and my wife were out in the country and I heard you being interviewed." He says, "Man," he says, "when I was being interviewed, this guy would get me so wrapped up I couldn't talk." He knew everything. He says he was getting it.

MR: Well maybe it's time for another book, huh?

BB: No, one is enough. I've got a lot of things I could—

MR: What do you think is the—

BB: Why don't you write a book?

MR: I think it will. Especially after today.

BB: You should. Everybody should. Everybody should. You know like I tell the guys I says make a diary, every day. I've got a little machine, you know, you just, when you think of a story just tell the machine. And at the end of a week or so, copy all of them down. That's what I more or less did.

MR: You'll have a lot of material in a hurry, yeah.

BB: Well I just kept on putting it down on a little cassette or something. You should. You've got a great name, Monk.

MR: I've got that going for me. Well do you remember a particular—

BB: And Rowe you know, you know, you know—

MR: Now I forgot my question.

BB: When we were down in the village, this is before I met any of them guys, maybe I knew Flip, but then we had a trio, a bass, a piano and a guitar. That was like a big hot trio. Carl Senior was the piano player. But Bob Rowe was the bass player. And Bob Rowe — this was down on Bleecker Street and it's right on the corner, it's still a bar, and a wild little place.

MR: In the village.

BB: Yeah. Everybody came in and sit in with this little trio. Bob Rowe had three strings on his bass. It was a three string bass. To this day I've never seen one. And he also played a little guitar, he was sort of a Django Reinhardt type. But anyway, well I didn't mean to get off, but he had your last name. And he wound up to be the principal bass player in the New Orleans Symphony. Me and my wife went out there when I was on the road, and I looked him up. And him and his wife, Dotty, who he was going — she sent him to Juilliard, and she worked as a waitress and let him go to Juilliard, and he became a classical bass player. Very intelligent guy too. But he took us out there and it was a groovy night in New Orleans. First he took us out — first we'd have like some kind of soup and crabs or something, in one place. Then we'd go to another place and have some kind of fish. Then we'd go to another place and have our dessert. In the meantime we were walking all over, it took the whole night, just going to different kinds of places. Pretty groovy.

MR: It sounds like a swinging town.

BB: Yeah. Well that's where he wound up.

MR: Can you think of when one of the hardest recordings you ever participated in? Would it have been some of the more modern stuff? Or don't you even look at it that way?

BB: You mean when I got tied up inside. Well there was a couple of times. With Stravinsky, forget about it.

MR: Tell me about that, will you, the Stravinsky?

BB: Was it Stravinsky or Stokowski? Stokowski. The conductor.

MR: Oh, Stokowski, yes.

BB: At NBC.

MR: Oh, yeah, at NBC.

BB: But the other one—

MR: Stravinsky wrote the piece for Woody Herman.

BB: Yeah but he just come back — he got us together in maybe a half hour. We were trying to play it, we couldn't. Because it wasn't just the rhythms. Everybody had different little things you know. But he come in and clapped his hands like this [claps]. And we all gathered, and he says — the classical guys were telling him what to do.

MR: Yeah. Stokowski.

BB: But one of my hardest things, well this wasn't in the book so I could tell you, like it was a band with strings and everything, a commercial date, but with strings and everything, it was very fast. And the guitar had to play all afterbeats. And in the middle I'd get mixed up. It was long, like about four or five minutes, and they had the guitar piped up. No piano, just bass and drums and this guitar had to get that afterbeat. That's tough. I mean very fast too. And he'd stop and he'd say, "You're very important." I finally got it. He says, "That's all right." Well that's hard. Like it wasn't a ridiculous thing to do—

MR: If you got off once, all of a sudden you're on the downbeats instead of the ups.

BB: Oh that happened down in the village with Jacques Brel's "Alive and Dead" or "Dead and Alive" whatever.

MR: Oh yes. "Alive and Well."

BB: Yes. They had a little quartet down there. And Wayne Wright sent me in as a sub. And I got along all right. But there was seven-eight time and things like that you know. And the keyboard player didn't play piano, he played all kinds of, what the hell they call it. The drummer was never, never just rhythm, just me and the bass. I think Teddy Kotick was the bass player. So there was one in seven-eight time. Again I had the afterbeats. And it was one, zing, one, zing, one, zing zing. One, zing, one, zing— And so it was all right the first show. Then we had a little time off, like the matinee, and we'd come back for that. In the meantime we'd go out and have a couple of drinks. It was funny. You know like little things like that, you figure you get all messed up with the big bunch of things, but the little things like this, they're so — well of course it's hard to be simple.

MR: It's hard to be simple in seven-eight.

BB: Well that's what I tell the guys, I says you know you're always looking all over the place and really it's right next to you. Like the upper and lower neighborhood. I mean they're looking all over and it's right next to them. You know like if you played a D flat seven to a C to make it. It's a substitution, but no they'd be looking all over. Well.

MR: Did we just run out of a tape?

BB: We must have.

MR: Okay, we'll wrap up here. Who do you listen to these days? Do you listen to any particular younger players?

BB: I listen to — see the way I do it, I tell them, they come to me as a teacher. I says I'm not a teacher, I'm an instructor. You're the teacher. If you can't teach yourself, you know I tell

you to do this, you keep doing this, and if you can't do it, then you can't teach yourself. So if you don't like me then don't come to me. But you go on your own. So what was the question?

MR: Talking about listening, if you have any favorites that you listen to now?

BB: No, what I do, I generally let them hear like I say, like if they sing sometimes I put "So What" on. Mainly I put that on, well it's the record, but it mainly is that if I'm showing them the Dorian mode say, it's a good example, because all they have to do is play in one key and then go up a half a tone higher, and back. So I get them, that they start to hear it, like that's all, and then I analyze some of [scats] see and I show them that that's only a couple of notes in the scale. So if he can do it you can. You know, like why are you running all over for? You know that's what I like, sort of. Anyway, what are we talking about again? Oh, showing them how simple, and why scales are important. Like if I say that's the Dorian mode, well man, the whole record they hardly play anything but the Dorian mode. Like when you analyze it, oh a couple of times they play a little out of the way.

MR: But they come back in.

BB: Yeah, yeah, yeah. Like see for one here, you know when you argue with me why do I have to know my scales, that's why. And I can talk to you. I says like I explain that. When they argue with me, I says, "I know you don't have to know it," I says, "But you're looking at a guy who happens to have everything else." I says, "You're like Tal Farlow. He don't practice scales, it's true." I says, "But you whistle a scale and here Tal was right with you." I says that's the difference, you can't do that.

MR: Well it sounds like your students are fortunate to be working with you, I would say that.

BB: Well I've got some guys that were hanging around me for 20 years. You know they don't come every week, but they'll take a year off and then they'll ring up, "I need a little brush up."

MR: Well this has really been a pleasure for me to talk to you, and I appreciate—

BB: I hope you think so when you see it.

MR: I hope so too.

BB: Maybe this will be it. Thanks for coming, I hope it's not snowing. You know of all the days that it snowed, it didn't snow, I don't think it snowed the whole winter.

MR: Right. Just our luck.

BB: A blizzard.

MR: Right. Well thanks for your time. I hope you have a safe trip back, and you've had a marvelous career and I appreciate your sharing it with me today.

BB: I'm glad, I mean I have no, you know like if you ask me what would I do, I don't think I could do anything else. I enjoyed it most of the time, most of the time I enjoyed it. I

wasn't begrudging anybody, I wasn't mad at somebody because they did it better. I mean I don't look at life that way.

MR: Right.

BB: This is the way I did it and that's why I'm telling you to write a book, him, the guy that's taking all these pictures, he should write a book. Everybody. Like what else is there to do?

MR: Okay.

BB: So a hundred years from now somebody, if they're fortunate, they'll be able to see.

MR: They'll be able to see it. All right.

BB: Well bye bye.

MR: Thanks for your time.